Lalu constantly prompting her from the sidelines. One sensed his time was up and the revolution he once championed had devoured him. And yet, one couldn't help but admire his principled stand against majoritarian communalism through good times and bad. Call it my fondness for the underdog (or lovable crook), but Lalu for me was sui generis.

Rahul obviously didn't share my affection for Lalu. But while he dithered on even this one alliance, Modi and the BJP pushed ahead with the ticket distribution. In a meeting with RSS leaders, the BJP strategists had made it clear—this time, winnability was the defining criteria, emotions had to be set aside. Predictably, the old order in the BJP made one last attempt to have its way. L.K. Advani, for example, wanted to move from his Gandhinagar seat and contest from Bhopal instead. He was worried, he told friends, that Modi would sabotage him in Gujarat, and preferred the 'safety' of Madhya Pradesh. The new BJP leadership held firm, calling it a bogus argument. 'Advaniji was again trying to create a false conflict between Modi and Shivraj Chauhan—we would have none of it, ' a senior BJP leader told me. Advani had to stay put in Gandhinagar.

Another veteran BJP leader, Jaswant Singh, had even less luck. He was keen to contest from his hometown of Barmer in Rajasthan. The party had reluctantly agreed but Rajasthan Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje put her foot down. 'His wife once filed an FIR against me, he has spoken ill of me. He cannot be given the ticket,' she insisted.

Jaswant was always a bit of an odd man out in the BJP. A former armyman who loved his Scotch and literature, he was a reminder—with his clipped British major accent delivered in his fruity baritone—almost a caricature, of a bygone colonial era. He had been forced out of the BJP in 2009 after writing a book which suggested that Jinnah, the founder of modern Pakistan, had been unfairly demonized. Even after he returned to the party, he had few friends left in the BJP. His only real ally, Vajpayee, was now too infirm to help him. At seventy-six, he was now part of the BJP's past; Vasundhara was its present. His ticket was denied, which led him to leave the party. In the midst of his revolt, Jaswant gave me a notable